THE SPEARHEAD

Javelin marvel **Neeraj Chopra** followed on Bindra's heels by winning India's first individual track and field gold at the 2020 (held in 2021) Tokyo Olympics. In fact, the boy from a village in Panipat, Haryana, went one better with a silver at Paris four years later. Neeraj has been one of India's most consistent athletes, winning golds at major international events almost every year since 2018. One major peak still to be conquered is the 90-metre mark, but then he is still only 26 and his best years are still ahead of him.



GETTY IMAGES

THE ECHO EFFECT

» **He was preceded by the likes of Rajyavardhan Rathore and Jaspal Rana. But it's after Bindra that shooting truly went mainstream**

» **Always considered an elite sport before him, a large number of kids took up the sport after his historic gold at the 2008 Beijing Olympics**

» **Govt outlays, private interest increased; ranges mushroomed**

» **Bindra inspired future medalists like Manu Bhaker, Sarabjot Singh and Swapnil Kusale**

"We have to be a little insane to do this, almost as single-minded as shaven monks who sit for years meditating under trees"

— **ABHINAV BINDRA,** *in his book,* A Shot At History

21
SHOOTERS
The record size of the Indian contingent to the Paris Olympics 2024, joint highest with China, was the same as the one that went to Beijing in 2008. London 2012 had 11; Rio 2016 had 15

DID YOU KNOW?

Abhinav is a sixth-gen descendant of the legendary Sikh general Hari Singh Nalwa from his mother's side

Yes, there's a bumper harvest of them now, and Manu Bhaker is only the most famous. But you count all athletes who gun for Olympic gold. Who *know* they are in the hunt: the Sindhus, the Chanus, the Phogats, the SatChis.... Including Neeraj Chopra, the one who chased the spoor all the way to the kill, they all strut about distant stadia now as if the world is their oyster, and they could have it raw.

As for shooting, it exploded like an ordnance factory catching fire. Ranges mushroomed, at times basic, in schools, villages. Government infrastructure spread beyond Delhi. Even air rifle, a sport with little viewership, attracted thousands of participants. Bindra's journey, while long and arduous, wasn't haunted by poverty. His wasn't the story of the indigent athlete with no money for shoes; he trained in Germany with a private coach. But that too set a template, spurring the government to finance foreign coaching and exposure trips for promising talent. Sponsors followed suit. That's how a rural-born Chopra repeated that route map. Bindra's real wealth, that monk-like calm, too hid a fire. As he said, "Just below my apparent calm, there is tremendous conflict. To win, you need an internal rage, a desperation." All that showed, from that day in Beijing, was an afterglow. ■